Unit 2: Qualitative Research and Inquiry
Main Idea: Understanding and explaining an issue is as important as devising a solution
Essential Question: How would you know if your topic is suited for qualitative research?
Essential Question: What course of action would you take if your research was considered crucial to the development of your field but did not adhere to ethical standards?

Characteristics of Qualitative Research

- Qualitative research occurs in the field or in a natural setting where the phenomenon is happening. The researcher engages with the people directly involved and often acclimate themselves to the views, beliefs, and culture of the community in focus.

- Researchers act as the key instrument in collecting data for qualitative research. The interactions, direct observations, and subjective analysis of the researcher and participants become part of the research process and collected data.

- The participant and their subjective views on a particular phenomenon are put into emphasis in a qualitative study. These different perspectives are highlighted when presenting the findings of the study.

- Qualitative research uses multiple sources of data and analysis. Data can be collected using interviews, focus group discussions, observations, document reviews, and audio-visual information. Although these methods are not based on a unified theoretical and methodological concept, criteria and protocols are developed to ensure that findings are grounded in empirical data.

Strengths and Weaknesses of Qualitative Research Methods

Semi-structured interviews	
Strengths	• Prevents imposing biases • Important means to dig down information using open-ended questions • Ensures mutual understanding between participant and interviewer
Weakness	• Tendency to ask leading questions • Interviews and analysis can be both time-consuming, subjective, and not generalizable • Participants' accounts always mean something, but they cannot always be taken at face value

Observations	
Strengths	• First-hand account of observing, prevents imposition of preconceived ideas and explore unforeseen effects
Weakness	• Observations and analysis can be time-consuming and are not generalizable • Observer's presence may influence participants • Observer may misinterpret actions, may be subjective

Focused group discussion	
Strengths	• Less expensive than individual interviews • Provides a relaxed atmosphere so that people feel free to express their views and strengths • Responses can be more spontaneous than in a one-to-one interview
Weakness	• Findings are not generalizable unless sampling techniques are used to constitute the groups • Depends on people's ability to talk in groups; group dynamics may inhibit people

Research Ethics and Guidelines

- Research ethics ensures that every part of the study can balance the values and morals of both researcher and subject/respondent.

Ethical Goals of a Researcher

- Ensure that people participate voluntarily in the study
- Keep people's comments and behavior confidential
- Protect people from harm
- Ensure mutual trust between researcher and participants

Six (6) Ethical Principles

- Beneficence
  - Researchers are ethically obligated to maximize benefit and minimize harm. The study puts emphasis on the research design being sound and the researchers having the appropriate competencies.

- Veracity or Justice
  - The truth must always be stated, and all agreements or promises must be met. Researchers are morally obligated to treat each person what is morally proper and due to him/her. Additionally, both benefits and burdens must be equally distributed to all participants.
  - Vulnerability may provide an exception to the equal distribution of benefits and burdens of the study. This is defined as a substantial incapacity to protect one's own interest, identity, consent, and well-being.

- Voluntary Participation/Respect for Persons
  - Participants must be aware that their participation in the study is voluntary and that they are free to withdraw at any time without unfavorable repercussions. Respect for persons is based on the respect for autonomy and protection of said persons.

- Anonymity and Confidentiality
  - Researchers seek to protect subjects' identity, interests, and future well-being. Researchers must be able to identify their responses, but not their identities. Individuals should have the right to limit access to information about themselves and control the use of this information.

- Disclosure
  - This sets a boundary on what to disclose to the participant regarding the study. It is important to note that although it is required for researchers to disclose information about the study, this must be carefully considered so that the respondents' opinions and responses will not be affected or influenced (e.g., if the research is focused on collecting negative reviews about a certain product, stating this specific objective to the participant may sway their responses and result in bias).

- Consent
  - Informed consent is an operational principle that allows participants to know that they are being researched, the nature of this research, and that they have the right to withdraw. This addresses four (4) areas of concern in research:
    - Giving relevant information about the research to the subject for them to decide whether to participate
    - Making sure that subjects understand information by writing it in the subject's language and capacity
    - Ensuring that participation is voluntary by requiring written consent
    - Subjects that are not competent to agree must be given consent by a proxy.

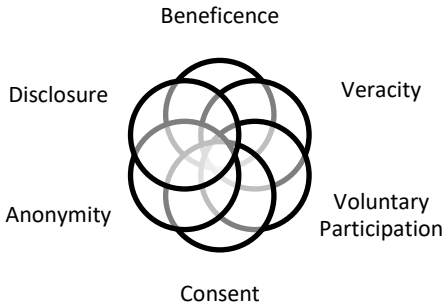


Figure 1. *Six (6) Ethical Principles of Research*

Ethical Pitfalls and Common Ethical Problems

- Exploitative social research
- Deception
- Identification of subjects' identities
- Fraternizing with disliked groups
- Participation in dubious bargains
- Research as a therapeutic action *(researchers choose a topic that they are personally involved in)*
- Research is conducted without a good background of safety precautions
- Family members and friends are used as participants

Informed Consent

Below is an example of an informed consent form.

References:

Marquez-Fong, S. R., & Tigno, C. R. (2016). *Practical research 1.* Quezon City: Vibal Group, Inc.

Melegrito, M. F., Mendoza, D. J., & Mactal, R. B. (2017). *Applied research: An Introduction to qualitative research methods and report writing.* Quezon City: Pheonix Publishing House, Inc.

Smith, D. (2003, January). Five Principles for Research Ethics. *American Psychological Association, 34*(1), 56.

Torneo, A., & Clamor-Torneo, H. (2018). *An introduction to qualitative research: Practical research 1.* Quezon City: Sibs Publishing House, Inc.

Informed Consent Form

Research Project Title:

Researchers:

Research Adviser:

Participant/s name/s:

This informed consent form has two (2) parts: (a) **information sheet** that is intended to share information about the study and (b) mandatory **consent form** where your written decision to participate or not in the study is indicated.

INFORMATION SHEET

1. Introduction
2. Purpose of the Study
3. Study Procedures
4. Duration
5. Voluntary Participation
6. Benefits and Reimbursement
7. Confidentiality
8. Contact Information

CONSENT FORM

I, _____, Filipino, of legal age, and with sound judgment, have reviewed the foregoing details in the information sheet. I understand that my words and responses will be used as stated above and that I may request a copy of these transcripts to review, edit, and remove as I deem necessary. I am aware of the benefits, burdens, and reimbursements that this study will provide in exchange for my participation. I have had the opportunity to ask all relevant questions and that these have been answered honestly and accurately by the researchers to my satisfaction. Lastly, I understand that my participation is voluntary and that I have the right to withdraw at any time with no unfavorable repercussions.

_____ _____

Printed Name and Signature of Participant *Date*

_____ _____

Printed Name and Signature of Witness *Date*

_____ _____

Printed Name and Signature of Research Adviser *Date*

*Ensure that this form is returned two (2) days after receipt

CONSENT FORM

If illiterate:

I, _____, Filipino, of legal age, and with sound judgment, have reviewed the foregoing details in the information sheet on behalf of _____ who is unable to review or provide their written consent without aid. I confirm that their words and responses will be used as stated above and that they may request a copy of these transcripts to review, edit, and remove as I deem necessary. I confirm that they are aware of the benefits, burdens, and reimbursements that this study will provide in exchange for their participation. I confirm that they have had the opportunity to ask all relevant questions and that these have been answered honestly and accurately by the researchers to their satisfaction. Lastly, I confirm that they understand that their participation is voluntary and that they have the right to withdraw at any time with no unfavorable repercussions.

_____	_____
Printed Name and Signature of Representative	*Date*
_____	_____
Printed Name and Signature of Participant	*Date*
_____	_____
Printed Name and Signature of Witness	*Date*
_____	_____
Printed Name and Signature of Research Adviser	*Date*

*Ensure that this form is returned two (2) days after receipt